

Trilobites

For more than 250 million years, the ancient seas teemed with trilobites—prehistoric animals related to today's insects, woodlice, and crabs. There were more than 17,000 different types of trilobite, ranging from the flea-sized to monsters twice the size of this book. Most crawled along the ocean floor in search of food, but a few were swimmers or floaters that drifted through the water.

Ditomopyge

DIT-o-mo-PY-gee

- **When** 300–251 million years ago (Late Carboniferous to Late Permian)
- **Fossil location** N. America, Europe, Asia, W. Australia
- **Habitat** Seafloor
- **Length** 1–1¼ in (2.5–3 cm)

Ditomopyge lived toward the end of the trilobites' reign, just before the age of the dinosaurs. It had a hard outer skeleton (exoskeleton) made up of overlapping plates covering its body segments. Underneath, each segment had a pair of wriggling legs. The head was protected by a large shield with backward-pointing spines and would have sported a pair of flexible antennae (feelers) for finding the way and tasting food.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Head shield
- Segmented, three-lobed body
- Many had compound eyes
- External skeleton (exoskeleton)

When

Trilobites appeared in the Cambrian Period, 526 million years ago, and disappeared at the end of the Permian Period, 250 million years ago, when the last species was wiped out.